stack

Business plan.
Own it. Play it everywhere.

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Executive summary

Stack lets people play the vinyl and CDs they already own on any device, share them with their household, and sell them on when they are done. Owning the record is free to play; Stack earns when people share (Duo £10 and Family £19.99 a month), buy the Puck (from £30), or trade on the Marketplace (8% seller fee).

A working prototype has been tested with 11 people aged 20 to 65, leading to six changes. Stack launches in Manchester through independent record shops. After a six-month pilot, the plan forecasts £246k revenue in Year 1, rising to £1.4m in Year 2 and £4.6m in Year 3, with break-even in Q3 of Year 2. I am asking for £200,000 to make the first Pucks, run the Manchester pilot and reach break-even.

Opportunity and customer problem

Collectors pay twice for the same music. Someone who owns *The Dark Side of the Moon* on vinyl still pays a streaming service to hear it on the bus, and their collection cannot be shared with the rest of their household. Physical ownership and digital listening sit in separate worlds.

The opportunity is growing. UK vinyl sales reached £174.4m in 2025, up 19.9% and the highest in around 30 years (Marsden, 2026), while the wider UK recorded music market grew for an eleventh consecutive year to £1.57bn (BPI, 2026). Half of US vinyl buyers do not own a record player (Jones, 2023), which suggests people buy records to own them and listen elsewhere. Stack closes that gap.

Customer research and validation

Stack was developed through Ries's (2011) build, measure, learn loop. Eleven people aged 20 to 65 tested the prototype in October 2026, ten on their own phones. Testers included a vinyl shop owner, students and working adults; most were friends and family, which I treat as a bias toward positive feedback.

Six changes came directly from feedback (full log in Appendix A):

- **Brand:** one tester said the black and orange scheme resembled an adult website's branding, so Stack moved to a warm 1970s palette.
- **Price:** the same tester found the Puck too expensive at £70, so it was cut to £30, with bundles of two for £50 and three for £75.

- **Clarity:** testers found the app's purpose and record views confusing, which led to an intro film and the list and crate views.
- **Features:** a tester asked for social features and a marketplace, which became the Friends tab and the Marketplace.

Further changes came from my own daily testing, such as making Solo free so people never pay to play records they own. Desk research also challenged the idea: labels report that under 25% of vinyl download codes are redeemed (Henshall, 2019). Stack must therefore offer more than a digital copy, which is why sharing and the Marketplace sit at its centre. The next test is willingness to pay for Duo and Family.

Market size, competitors and positioning

The UK recorded music market is worth £1.57bn, of which vinyl is £174.4m (BPI, 2026; Marsden, 2026). Stack's obtainable market is far smaller: an average of 10,000 people in Manchester in Year 1, growing to 200,000 across the UK by Year 3.

Competitors each solve one part of the problem:

Competitor	What it does	What it lacks
Spotify, Apple Music	Huge streaming catalogues	You never own anything
Discogs	Catalogue and second-hand marketplace	You cannot listen
Bandcamp	Physical plus digital, artist by artist	Only records bought there
Vinyl Recorder app (Roberts, 2017)	Recorded vinyl to a phone, paid per track	Needed a USB turntable; no sharing

Using Blue Ocean thinking (Kim and Mauborgne, 2005), Stack avoids competing with streaming on catalogue size. It creates value no rival offers together: listening, sharing and selling the records you own. Porter's (2008) five forces highlight the main threat as supplier power, because labels control the licences Stack needs.

Value proposition and prototype

Stack's promise is "Own it. Play it everywhere." A record is added once, by barcode, Discogs import or the Puck, then plays in lossless on any device, shared with the household and sellable when no longer wanted. The Puck sits between turntable and speakers: sound passes straight through while it records the owner's copy and logs every play.

The prototype is a working web app at harrisongreener.github.io/stack. It tests whether people understand and want the core idea. Its main features are:

- **My Stack:** a collection shown as covers, a crate or a list.
- **Two-deck player:** for playing records.
- **Family Stack:** a shared collection for the household.
- **Friends:** activity, badges and listening rooms.
- **Marketplace:** second-hand sales with ownership transfer.

Screenshots are in the portfolio.

Business model

The model was mapped on a Lean Canvas (Maurya, 2012) and works as a loop. Playing your own records is free, which removes the barrier to joining. Stack earns when people:

Stream	Price	Role
Duo and Family sharing plans	£10 and £19.99 a month	Main profit
The Puck	£30; 2 for £50; 3 for £75	Brings people in, sold close to cost
Marketplace	8% seller fee	Keeps records moving
Seller Pro	£6.99 a month, 5% fee	For record shops and frequent sellers
Stack Supply and shop partners	Merchandise and commission	Brand and extra income

The Puck is deliberately a low-margin product. Its parts cost about £15–22 at 1,000 units (LionCircuits, no date; Andertons, no date), so at £30 it gets records onto Stack rather than making profit, a common pattern in hardware (Einstein, 2015).

Route to the first 3–5 users and 90-day actions

The first users will come from the record shop counter. Rogers's (2003) diffusion of innovations suggests targeting innovators and early adopters first, and in music these are the collectors who already visit independent shops. The hook for shops is free help listing their second-hand stock on the Marketplace, using a photo quick-add feature that recognises the record and suggests a price.

1. **Weeks 1–4:** visit Manchester shops that sell second-hand records: Vinyl Exchange, Clampdown, Tasty Records, Music For The Soul and Wax and Beans (Manchester's Finest, 2026). Goal: two pilot shops signed.
2. **Weeks 5–8:** list their stock on Stack and put stickers and posters in store. Goal: the first 3–5 users from shop customers.
3. **Weeks 9–12:** hold a listening party at a partner shop, launch invite-a-friend and offer Seller Pro to pilot shops. Goal: 100 people and 10 paying homes.

This follows Sarasvathy's (2001) effectual logic: start from existing contacts, such as the pop-up shop owner who tested the app, and build partnerships before paying for advertising.

Operations, people, legal, ethical and data obligations, sustainability

Operations and people. I designed and built the prototype and will run product and shop partnerships during the pilot. The first hire in Year 1 is a developer to build the licensed streaming back end; a partnerships lead, a second developer and support follow in Year 2. Pucks are made in small batches by a contract manufacturer and sold through partner shops and the app.

Legal, ethical and data obligations:

- **Music licensing:** owning a record does not give the right to stream or copy it. Stack launches only with licences from labels and publishers, paying royalties on every play.
- **Data protection:** collections, listening history and location are personal data under UK GDPR. Stack will ask for consent, store data in the UK, and let users export or delete it at any time.

- **Product safety:** the Puck needs UKCA and CE marking and safety testing, and falls under the WEEE take-back rules for electronics.
- **Consumer rights:** Marketplace buyers are protected by holding payment until the record arrives and by honest condition grading.

Sustainability. Selling records on keeps vinyl in use instead of in landfill. The Puck will use a recycled plastic case and minimal packaging, and faulty units will be repaired before being replaced.

Finances, funding, risks and milestones

Pricing and sales assumptions. One in eight people on Stack shares at home (1,250 homes on average in Year 1), split 60% Duo and 40% Family, an average of £14 a month. Forty per cent of homes that join each year buy Pucks, spending £40 on average. Each sharing home buys £24 of second-hand records a year. People-on-Stack figures are yearly averages. Growth is steady rather than sudden: from 1,000 people at the end of the pilot to about 20,000 by the end of Year 1, 100,000 by the end of Year 2 and 300,000 by the end of Year 3, adding one region at a time through partner shops.

Costs. I assume rights holders take two-thirds of sharing revenue, in line with what Spotify pays (Del Fabbro, 2025). Card fees are 1.5% + 20p (Hammond, 2026); other costs are estimates.

	Year 1	Year 2	Year 3
Average people on Stack	10,000	60,000	200,000
Revenue	£246k	£1.42m	£4.63m
Rights holders (two-thirds of sharing)	£140k	£840k	£2.80m
Puck parts and shipping	£31k	£130k	£342k
Team	£86k	£199k	£348k
Marketing	£30k	£80k	£300k
Hosting, payments and overheads	£35k	£151k	£456k
Profit	**–£75k**	**£18k**	**£382k**

Cashflow and break-even. The model runs quarter by quarter as people join (Appendix C). After the £30k pilot, Stack loses money through Year 1 (–£75k) while it grows. Year 2 opens with new hires, so cash reaches its low point of –£150k in Q2 of Year 2. Stack makes a quarterly profit from Q3 of Year 2 (+£18k), which is break-even.

Scenarios for Year 2. Bad case (half the sharing homes, half the Puck buyers): –£187k. Expected: +£18k. Good case (50% more homes): +£221k.

Funding and use of funds. I am asking for £200,000 from angel investors plus a Start Up Loan: £30,000 for the pilot (500 Pucks £10k, case mould £10k, safety testing £5k, pilot marketing £3k, hosting and licensing £2k) and £170,000 working capital. This covers the £150k low point with a £50k buffer, but not the full bad case, which would need a further raise or slower hiring.

Key risks.

Risk	Response
Labels refuse or delay licences	Start with labels that already include download codes; no launch without licences
Puck costs exceed £30	Barcode and Discogs import work without it; small batches
Empty Marketplace	Partner shops list stock from day one
Testers were mostly friendly	Wider paid-plan tests in shops before launch

Milestones. Pilot month 3: two shops, 100 people, 10 paying homes. Pilot month 6: five shops, 1,000 people, 125 paying homes. End of Year 1: about 20,000 people in Manchester. Year 2: the North West, with break-even in Q3. Year 3: the UK.

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Appendix A: decision log

Tester	Who	When	How	What they said	What changed
P4	20, waitress	Early Oct, before 8 Oct	Own phone	Old colours resembled an adult website's branding; Puck at £70 too expensive	70s palette (8 Oct); Puck £30 (19 Oct)
P7	29, doctor	Early Oct, before 8 Oct	Own phone	Not clear what the app was	Intro film (8 Oct)
P9	65, retired teacher	Early Oct, before 8 Oct	Own phone	The way records are viewed was confusing	List view, then crate view (8 Oct)
P2	20, freelancer	About 15 Oct	Own phone	Better than other vinyl apps; wanted social features and a marketplace	Marketplace (17 Oct); Friends (19 Oct)
P5, P6, P8, P10, P11	Aged 21–59	10–20 Oct	Own phones	Liked it; no changes suggested	None
P1	48, vinyl shop owner	21 Oct	On my phone, at a uni vinyl pop-up	Young people would connect with it; would use it to sell	None; confirmed the Marketplace
P3	31, teacher	21 Oct	Own phone	"Why doesn't this already exist?"	None; confirmed the problem

Appendix B: founder testing

Date	What I found	What changed
21–22 Oct	Paying to play your own records felt wrong	Solo made free; pay only to share
19 Oct	Marketplace too basic	Search, grading, offers, chat, price history
9 Oct	Every record looked the same	Vinyl colour picker for real pressings
9 Oct	My Stack felt cluttered	Notification bell
8–9 Oct	Sound failed on iPhone	Fixed audio and two-deck player
8 Oct	Browsing covers one by one was slow	Crate view, search, A–Z dividers

Appendix C: cashflow by quarter, pilot to Year 2

	Pilot	Y1 Q1	Y1 Q2	Y1 Q3	Y1 Q4	Y2 Q1	Y2 Q2	Y2 Q3	Y2 Q4
Revenue	–	£20k	£45k	£74k	£108k	£183k	£305k	£412k	£518k
Costs	£30k	£48k	£68k	£90k	£115k	£220k	£314k	£393k	£473k
Net	−£30k	−£28k	−£23k	−£16k	−£8k	−£36k	−£8k	+£18k	+£45k
Cash position	−£30k	−£58k	−£81k	−£97k	−£105k	−£142k	−£150k	−£132k	−£87k

Cash position before the £200,000 investment; figures rounded. The pitch deck, prototype and video are linked from the pitch site.